

WHAT TO LOOK FOR WHILE BUYING A WIRELESS ROUTER

Here are a few salient tips on how to shop for a wireless router, which is an essential feature of any modern organisation and home.

Choosing the appropriate wireless router for your business can be quite a task, because of the ever-changing technology, bandwidth requirements, variety of uses within the office premises, and the fact that you don't want to change the device in the next few years. You would obviously want to invest in something that delivers great performance along with adequate coverage, and offers long-term benefits. The highly technical specifications, however, do tend to confuse shoppers of wireless routers. So, before you get on with the job of buying a wireless router for your home or office, let's help you with a guide for buying (read: investing) in the device.

Why do you need a wireless router?

A wireless router can connect a device to the Internet wirelessly, and allows users to communicate with the external world. But do you really need a wireless router for this level of communication? In an office set-up, it is a much-needed device. Only if you have one user who works on a single laptop or PC, with no other devices being connected to the Internet, can you resort to a DSL modem rather than a wireless router. However, things have rapidly changed for users these days. With mobile devices coming in, people use multiple devices that connect to the Internet and hence, a wireless router has become a necessity. A wireless router allows you to go truly mobile.

How do you use your network?

While choosing a wireless router, you have to check your requirements first. If you have a set of basic users, who just have to surf the Internet and are looking for simple Wi-Fi connectivity, a single band router is a good choice. But if you have users who plan to perform some bandwidth-demanding tasks like heavy duty gaming or high-definition video streaming, you should go for a high-end wireless router.

Single band or dual band?

'Bands' is a frequently used term when it comes to wireless routers. Wireless communications operate on the 2.4GHz and 5GHz bands. While the single band routers are restricted to the 2.4GHz frequency, the dual band routers operate on both 2.4 and 5GHz frequencies. For users with throughput-intensive work including file streaming and gaming, 5GHz is a good choice, as it is less crowded and will deliver better internal

network performance as well. However, it has a downside too. The 5GHz band is unable to sustain signals at greater distances. So, a 5GHz router can work best for you if you have understood the distance factor, while placing the router in your home or office. In addition, you should also check what frequency your device supports, before you opt for any wireless router.

The router speed

This is yet another aspect that you have to keep in mind while buying the right router for your home or office. There is a three to four digit number attached to the routers—300 Mbps, 900 Mbps, 1900 Mbps, etc.—which indicates the speed of the router.

Don't go by these numbers, literally, when you determine the speed of your router. With the interferences present in the room, it is unlikely that you will get the exact router speed mentioned on your device. The fact is that the speeds mentioned with the routers denote what's possible in ideal conditions. So even if you get half the speed of what has been claimed, it's good enough.

However, don't mistake the router speed with the speed of your Internet connection. The latter depends on the speed provided by your service provider. The speed of the router manages your internal network and helps in tasks like streaming music, file sharing and so on.

What is 802.11n?

Whether you buy a single band or a dual band router, an 802.11n router is something that you should look for. But, as they say, technology is never stagnant. The latest is the 802.11ac in the 802.11 family. It is the most recent wireless networking standard and is capable of providing almost 1GBps throughput in ideal conditions. Go for it, if you need speed.

Security standards

This is the most important factor that IT heads consider while selecting a wireless router. Most routers available today provide WPA2 level security, which is by far the highest level. So, checking this standard is a good idea to protect your users from any possible cyber crime.

Some other points to consider

IPv6: Of course we are living in the IPv6 era, but we should not forget that the transition has happened just recently. So, while buying a new router, do remember that new standards have come in.

SD card slot and USB ports: For users who need external file sharing or printer sharing, a router with a USB port or an SD card slot is a good choice.